CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

PIPEFITTER IN THE AI ERA

Robots can weld in a factory. They still cannot fit, align and troubleshoot pipe inside a real plant.

★ TL;DR — Median ~$75,000 on a 2–4 year path through paid training and licensing. The catch: heavy physical work, shutdown schedules and jobs that follow industrial sites. ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

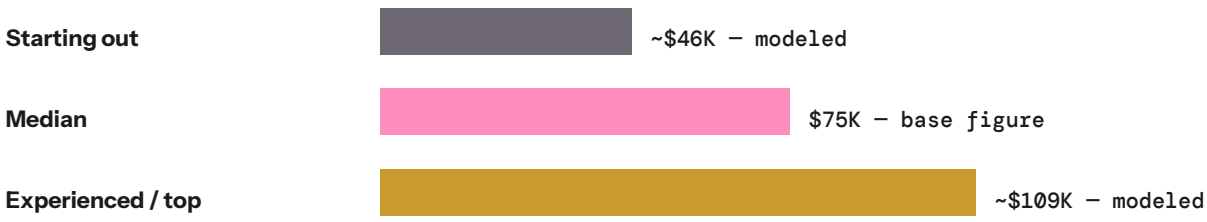
OUR TAKE: YES

MEDIAN ~$75K · TRAINING 2-4 years · AI RISK LOW · STATE LICENSE

- Industrial systems keep this work firmly in the physical world.
- The specialty and license separate a pipefitter from a general helper.
- Software can plan prefabrication, but field fit-up and repairs stay human.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for Pipefitter is a ~$75K median (compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A PIPEFITTER ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ Read drawings and measure pipe runs before cutting or joining anything
- ✓ Cut, thread, bend and assemble pipe, supports, valves and fittings

✓ Install piping connected to industrial and commercial equipment

✓ Pressure-test systems, find leaks and repair damaged sections

Think: the industrial counterpart to a plumber, working on systems built for pressure, heat and production.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
Design software handles layouts, material lists and prefabrication measurements. Sensors and digital records help track inspections and maintenance.	The judgment happens in awkward, changing field conditions: alignment, safe rigging, leak diagnosis and knowing when a shortcut creates a dangerous system.

⚠ **The money is not instant. You earn it through documented training, testing and physically demanding work, and some of the best-paid assignments require travel or outage schedules.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT
✓ Paid skill-building instead of years of unpaid study ✓ Large, tangible systems you can point to when they work ✓ A licensed specialty that can travel between industrial markets	✗ Heavy materials, heights, noise and confined spaces ✗ Shutdowns and deadlines that can swallow evenings and weekends ✗ Work locations decided by plants and construction projects

Good fit? You are mechanically minded, precise with measurements and comfortable working hard under strict safety rules.
Bad fit? You want a desk, a predictable address and clean hands every day.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — UNION APPRENTICESHIP	DOOR B — NON-UNION CONTRACTOR HELPER
Apply to a pipefitters local or joint apprenticeship program. Expect aptitude screening, an interview and paid classroom-plus-field training while your hours build toward the license.	Start as a helper or apprentice with a mechanical or industrial contractor. The entry can be faster, but ask who documents your hours and supports the licensing path.

Smart move: Target contractors serving plants, hospitals, energy sites and large commercial projects, then ask directly how they train and sponsor apprentices through the license.

Where you land after: Journeyman pipefitter, then foreman, general foreman, inspector, estimator or independent specialty contractor.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
MAP THE	BUILD THE	ENTER PAID	LEARN SYSTEM	PASS THE	SPECIALIZE AFTER

STEP 1 — Map the local market

FREE · TODAY

- List union programs, mechanical contractors and industrial employers hiring near you.
- Read your state and local licensing rules so you know which hours and exams count.

STEP 2 — Build the basics

FREE-LOW COST · BEFORE YOU APPLY

- Refresh trade math, measurement, fractions and blueprint basics.
- Learn hand-tool and power-tool safety; get any basic safety card local employers request.

STEP 3 — Enter paid training

PAID · TRAINING

- Apply for apprenticeship openings and take every required aptitude test or interview seriously.
- If you miss a class, take a helper role that keeps you close to pipefitting crews.

STEP 4 — Learn system by system

PAID · ON THE JOB

- Rotate through materials, supports, valves, rigging, layout and installation.
- Build welding and fabrication awareness even when another specialist performs the weld.

STEP 5 — Pass the license gate

VARIES · BY STATE

- Complete the required documented hours and classroom training.
- Prepare for and pass the journeyman or state licensing examination that applies locally.

STEP 6 — Specialize after the license

EARNED · AFTER LICENSING

- Choose a valuable lane such as process piping, steam, refrigeration piping or industrial maintenance.
- Use specialty credentials and a clean safety record to qualify for stronger crews and employers.

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

- □ Today: write down the local programs, contractors and licensing authority you need to contact.
- □ Days 1–30: study trade math, gather application documents and submit every open apprenticeship application.
- □ Days 31–60: complete safety preparation, interview practice and helper applications if formal classes are full.
- □ Days 61–90: work or shadow with a mechanical crew and confirm exactly how your training hours will be documented.
- □ Day 90: you should be in paid training, working as a helper, or holding a dated plan for the next apprenticeship intake.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest “probably NOT you”. → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ **REAL PIPES. REAL PRESSURE.** ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.